



It's A Mailbox, It's A Back-Up Drive, It's Gmail!

GMail gives you 1000 MB of storage space. Here's how to make the most of it

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Until about a few months ago, backing up your data and carrying it around was a breeze thanks to the availability of sites like X-drive and SwapDrive. Unfortunately, they went the commercial way leaving many a user in the lurch. Enter Gmail, with its 1000 MB storage in every mailbox. Apart from being a mailbox, this also re-opened doors for those interested in storing and backing up their data online.

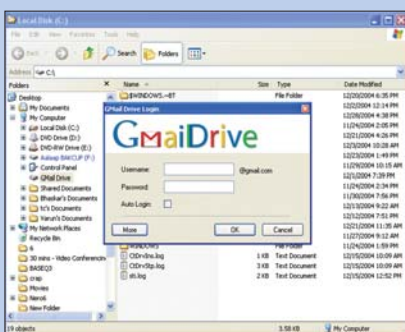
As changes abound in the service, several new tools are also being launched to work with the service. Gmail Drive is one such tool that allows you to easily backup and store data in your Gmail account.

1 STEP Downloading And Installing Gmail Drive

Gmail Drive is a Shell Namespace Extension that creates a virtual file system around your Gmail account so that you can use it as a storage medium. To download it, go to www.viskoe.dk. In the description on the homepage, find the 'projects' link. This will open a list of the projects including 'Gmail Drive'. Download the utility (approx. 120 KB), extract the contents from the .zip file, and run setup.exe to install the program.

2 STEP Setting Up Gmail Drive

After installing the program, a new drive, 'Gmail Drive', will appear in



Enter your Gmail ID and password to access Gmail Drive

Windows Explorer. You can access this with your Gmail login and password. You can also tick the 'Auto Login' box so that you are not prompted for your password each time. Once this is done, you can access the drive like any other on your computer.

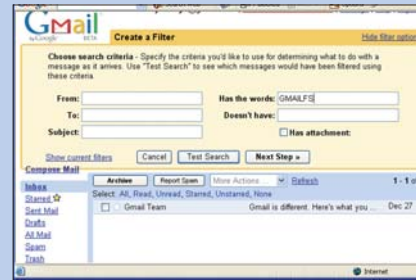
Ticking the 'Auto Login' box is useful if you plan to perform automated backups on your Gmail Drive. The drive can be operated like any other, and you can also perform all the functions you perform with other drives, including copying, pasting and deleting files, as well as searching. You can also use 'Send To' in the context menu to send these files to this drive.

How It Works

What actually takes place when you copy and paste files to the Gmail Drive is, they are e-mailed to your Gmail account as attachments. Gmail Drive periodically checks your account for new files and rebuilds the directory structure. If you log on to your Gmail account after pasting files in to your Gmail Drive, you will see some mails sent from your Gmail ID with the subject starting with 'GMAILFS'. These are the files you copied to your Gmail Drive being sent as attachments.

3 STEP Creating Filters In Gmail

As you back up more and more files, it can get tough to find the right file in a long list of e-mails. To make it easier, you could



Create a filter in Gmail to avoid your Inbox getting cluttered due to Gmail Drive

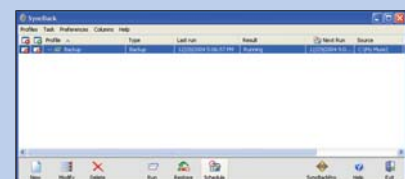
apply filters to your account and ensure that all backed-up files are automatically moved to a particular folder. To start with, you could move them all to the 'Archived Mail' folder. To set up filters in your e-mail account, you need to log in and click on the 'Create a filter' option. On the ensuing page, there will be various options and choices of filtering your mails. Choose the 'Have the words' option and type 'GMAILFS' in the box next to it.

On the next page, tick the 'Skip the Inbox (Archive it)' checkbox and finally on 'Create a Filter'.

Automating Backups

Gmail Drive can also be scheduled to perform auto-backups using software such as 'SyncBack'. This is a free backup utility. When using SyncBack, you are prompted to create a profile, click on 'Yes', select 'Backup' and enter a name for the profile.

To schedule the backup of a particular folder, provide the path in the 'Source' dialog box and your Gmail Drive address in the 'Destination' dialog box. Now just click on the 'Expert' button and click on the 'Misc' tab. On



Use a backup utility such as SyncBack to take automated backups to your Gmail drive

this page, you can schedule the backup to run at a specified time or at regular intervals based on your requirements.